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DESIGNTODAY

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SPACES ETCETERA



IN FOCUS

RETAIL DESIGN

Stores in Tel Aviv, Prague New Delhi & Amsterdam

Office Interiors, Bengaluru

A zesty informal setting

Luxury Housing, Brisbane

Homes by the riverfront

RNI NO. DELENG/2002/6742

THE INDIA TODAY GROUP

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PLUS: PASTELS IN FOCUS

The zones have been earmarked as living-dining settings so customers have a comprehensive spatial idea of the products, while the central area was planned for new launches

BREAK AWAY

COLLABORATIVE ARCHITECTURE SHAPES THE INTERIORS OF A LIFESTYLE SHOWROOM IN FARIDABAD KEEPING to a literal adherence of the brief. A parallel design was an exhibition space for the client in Mumbai. While the definitive plan was to develop a retail image, the emphasis was on evolving a design life cycle





Classe, a franchisee of a leading furniture brand, approached Collaborative Architecture for the design of their showroom in Faridabad. Their brief was, "No one should ask who did the interiors." The client quite firmly believed that the interior architecture of the boutique might overpower the products on display. So, rather than taking the route to proactive retail design, the effort here was to address the very concerns of an evolving client, by consciously stepping back and lending a neutral backdrop to the products.

The Faridabad showroom displays various products that cater to mid-level and high-end luxury residential and hospitality clients. A special area was carved out to house their office furniture line. The designers had to address the conflicting themes of being 'anonymous', to respect the brief, but at the same time sophisticated, to reflect the design direction of the product range.

The six-metre long, suspended reception counter sets the tone and direction of the store. This area showcases new arrivals and launches. The zones have been earmarked


Wedge-1


Wedge-1

The intent was to dissect the simple shoe box and manipulate the architectonic character of the box

as living-dining settings so that customers have a comprehensive spatial idea of the products.

Says architect Lalita Tharani of Collaborative Architecture, "The Faridabad store was done with debilitating design intent, where the client wanted a mute, neutral backdrop. Instead, Wedge-1 (the exhibition project) transforms the whole retail experience, elevating the brand presence and actively participating in the brand building. For a long time now, we've been talking about the need for retail environments to acquire a decent design life cycle, an idea greatly neglected and difficult to achieve."

Wedge-1 was an architectonic exploration by the firm in creating projects which are refined in architectural morphology. The intent was to dissect the simple 'shoe box' and manipulate the architectonic character of the box, in the most economical way, since the project was on a low budget.

The name 'wedge' comes from the character of the spaces within the dissected box, which largely are trapezoidal. The space was organised in a centripetal, pinwheel form. The central gathering space had wedges with undulating volumes and a roofline. The peripheral wall with its unique cut-outs set the tone of encounter with the exhibits that revealed and masked the displays simultaneously to lure a visitor to the stall.

White was used on the exhibit floor to heighten the perception of encounter with the products. The central gathering space had a series of light 'vectors' (1200 mm long T5 lamps), which formed an enclosing canopy that fused into the space to complete the box imagery.

Project Team: *Lalita Tharani, Mujib Ahmed, Mazhar, Munib, Vineeta and Shoukath.*


Wedge-1

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Photographs courtesy: **COLLABORATIVE ARCHITECTURE**